



Rating
Hold

North America
United States

Health Care
Managed Care

Company
UnitedHealth Group

Reuters
UNH.N

Bloomberg
UNH US

Date
17 July 2026

Rating	Hold
Price target (USD)	467.00
Price at 16 Jul 26	15.51
52-week range	431.68 – 15.51

[Valuation & Risks](#)

No Good Deed: UNH Delivers Robust Outlook, Shares Fade

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Strong Beat & Raise; 2026 Becomes Higher Baseline: UNH delivered an everything-investors-wanted quarter with a strong beat and raise, effectively squashing near-term concerns around MA MLR and the quality of the recovery. 2026 adjusted EPS guidance was raised by ~\$1.50 at the midpoint to \$19.50 to \$20.00, mostly reflecting the ~\$1.49 beat in the quarter and ahead of the \$18.49 consensus. The company also lowered and narrowed the full-year MLR guidance by ~70bps at the midpoint to 88.1% +/- 25bps. We suspect the raise could still prove conservative considering the potential for further improvements across the model: operating expenses remain elevated due to investments in people, communities and AI; provider cost pressure in Commercial remains high; OptumHealth is recovering faster than expected; Optum Insight is beginning to show AI-driven operating and product momentum; and stronger cash flow increases capital deployment flexibility. Management framed the \$19.50 to \$20.00 EPS range as the right baseline for 2027 growth, even though it includes prior period development, and reiterated confidence in the 13%–16% long-term EPS growth algorithm. Despite this better-than-expected print, the shares faded from opening ~+9% to end the session up only 1%, as the entire MCO space sold off despite the MCO leader's robust outlook.

Solid Q2 Beat With Broad-based Strength: UNH reported Q2 total revenue of \$112.0B, coming in above our \$110.0B estimate and the Street's \$110.6B, while adjusted EPS of \$6.38 was also well above our \$4.73 estimate and consensus of \$4.89. Consolidated MLR of 86.7% beat the consensus estimate by 170 bps, helped by \$860mm of net favorable prior period medical development, the majority of which was in-year development. Importantly, days claims payable increased to 47 days, up ~2.5 days year over year, which should provide comfort on reserving quality despite the favorable development. Management noted Medicare trend remains elevated versus historical levels but is running below its initial ~10% expectation, driven by benefit design, care management, network curation, product positioning, favorable claims experience, lighter respiratory season and weather patterns. MA membership retention is now expected to be better than prior expectations, with enrollment expected to decline by ~1.1mm lives for the year and Medicare margins expected to finish above 3%. Medicaid was broadly in line with expectations, with 2026 margins still expected within the prior negative 1.0% to negative 1.7% range. Annualized 2026 rate impacts are expected around 6%–7% but still lag elevated medical trend. Optum delivered strong results in Q2, with OptumHealth the standout as stronger care

Key changes

Price target (USD) 370 467 26%

Source: Deutsche Bank



management, operating discipline and payer alignment support a more visible margin recovery path from a little above 2% in 2026 toward ~4% in 2027 and the 6% aspirational level in 2028. Optum Rx remains steady with no major investment required for the new transparency model, while Optum Insight's Q2 upside benefited from payment integrity timing pull-forward, though the longer-term AI/product opportunity remains intact.

Commercial Is The Main Nit, But Also A Future Recovery Lever: The main offset was Commercial, where management said cost trend remains stubbornly high and modestly above the prior ~11% expectation. The drivers include pressure from the No Surprises Act independent dispute resolution process, higher provider coding intensity, higher service intensity and pharmacy cost pressure, including specialty drugs, anti-inflammatory drugs and GLP-1s. Management now expects Commercial margin recovery to take longer than previously anticipated, with full recovery extending past 2027, but characterized this as a delay rather than a setback. We view this as one of the important future upside levers: the current Commercial run-rate clearly pressures margins, but it also leaves room for recovery from pricing, administrative cost efficiency, AI-enhanced fraud/waste/abuse efforts and tighter medical cost management over time.

Adjusting Estimates: We are raising our 2026 revenue estimate from \$447.2B to \$448.9B, above the Street's \$444.0B. Our adjusted EPS estimate is increased from \$18.45 to \$19.94 reflecting the Q2 beat as well as expectations for stable trend in MA and Medicaid. This positions us close to the high end of the guidance range and above the \$18.49 consensus – which we suspect will move closer to \$20. We continue to see sources for upside to 2026 EPS including conservative MLR guidance, discretionary spend, capital deployment, and the potential for State rate improvements. UNH increased its guidance for CFO from \$18B to \$24B and doubled its share repo target to \$5B+.

Maintain Hold: We maintain our Hold rating on UNH's shares and raise our price target from \$370 to \$467 now representing 20x our 2027 EPS estimate. With two quarters of 2026 in the books, we are rolling forward to 2027 numbers for valuation purposes. Our target multiple reflects a comprehensive path towards margin expansion in 2026 and 2027 following the transition year that was 2025. Downside risks include worsening cost trends, inability to achieve prudent pricing and plan exits, healthcare regulatory changes at the federal and state levels, managed-care pricing competition, any impact from the reported DOJ investigation, and drug-pricing/PBM reform, which appear to be diminishing. Upside risks include better-than-expected execution of the margin recovery story and significant EPS outperformance versus our estimates and consensus. UNH delivered that outperformance today, which appeared to already be priced into the shares.



Figure 1: UNH Q Comp

UnitedHealth Group Q2-25 Results										
	Initial Outlook	FY-26 Q1 Guide	Q2 Guide	Consensus	Q2-25 DB	Actual	Q2-25	Consensus	Growth DB	Actual
Total Revenue	>\$439,000			\$ 110,667	\$ 110,034	\$ 112,032	\$ 111,616	-0.9%	-1.4%	0.4%
Total Operating Expenses				104,177	102,627	104,041	106,466			
EBITDA				7,377	7,407	9,031	6,234	18.3%	18.8%	44.9%
Depreciation and Amortization	-4,400			979	1,039	1,040	1,084		OP Margin	
Operating Income	>24,000		>25,450	6,525	6,103	7,991	5,150	5.96%	5.55%	7.13%
Interest Expense	-3,700			927	916	962	1,027			
Pre-Tax Income				5,412	5,380	6,968	4,082	32.6%	31.8%	70.7%
Income Taxes				1,063	1,130	1,298	510			
Tax Rate	-19.25%		-18.5%	19.6%	20.7%	18.5%	12.4%			
Net Income	>15,600		>16,750	4,236	4,250	5,670	3,572	18.6%	19.0%	58.7%
Noncontrolling interests				183	(201)	(186)	(166)			
Adjusted Net Income				4,439	4,314	5,792	3,716	19.4%	16.1%	55.9%
Adjusted EPS	>\$17.75	>\$18.25	\$19.50-\$20.00	\$4.89	\$4.73	\$6.38	\$4.08	19.7%	15.8%	56.3%
Diluted Share Count	910-915			908	912	906	910			
UnitedHealthcare										
Revenue	>335,000			84,911	82,616	86,017	86,103	-1.4%	-4.0%	-0.1%
Adj. Operating Profit	>10,800		>12,000	3,104	3,387	3,942	2,075	49.6%	63.2%	90.0%
OP margin	-3.2%			3.7%	4.1%	4.6%	2.4%			
MLR	88.3%-89.3%		87.85%-88.35%	88.4%	88.5%	86.7%	89.4%			
Eliminations				-	-	-	-			
Optum										
OptumHealth										
Revenue	>91,000			23,218	22,407	23,472	24,725	-6.1%	-9.4%	-5.1%
Adj. Operating Profit	>2,200 (GAAP)		>2,215	481	479	1,174	636	-24.3%	-24.6%	84.6%
OP margin	-2.4%			2.1%	3.32%	5.00%	2.6%			
OptumInsight										
Revenue	>21,000			5,292	5,227	5,402	5,232	1.1%	-0.1%	3.2%
Adj. Operating Profit	>4,750 (GAAP)		>4,750	1,169	943	1,373	998	17.1%	-6.6%	37.6%
OP margin	-22.6%			22.1%	18.0%	25.4%	19.1%			
OptumRx										
Revenue	>150,500			37,646	40,524	38,292	38,459	-2.1%	5.4%	-0.4%
Adj. Operating Profit	>6,250		>6,250	1,501	1,559	1,490	1,441	4.2%	8.2%	3.4%
OP margin	-4.2%			4.0%	3.85%	3.89%	3.7%			
Optum Eliminations	-(5,000)			(1,204)	(1,071)	(1,503)	(1,191)	1.1%	-10.1%	26.2%
OptumRx Quarterly Adj Scripts (mlns)				-	-	387	414			-6.5%
UnitedHealth Membership Data										
Commercial Risk-Based	6,765-6,965			7,344	7,730	7,655	8,440	-13.0%	-8.4%	-9.3%
Commercial Fee-Based	22,035-22,235			22,275	22,278	22,265	21,530	3.5%	3.5%	3.4%
Total Commercial Enrollment	28,800-29,100			29,619	30,008	29,920	29,970	-1.2%	0.1%	-0.2%
Medicare Advantage	7,245-7,295			7,444	7,265	7,565	8,350	-10.9%	-13.0%	-9.4%
Medicare Supplement	4,235-4,285			4,266	4,265	4,260	4,305	61.6%	-0.9%	-1.0%
Stand-Alone PDP	2,670-2,670			2,697	2,706	2,710	2,800	-3.7%	-3.4%	-3.2%
Total Medicare & Retirement	14,050-14,250			14,407	14,236	14,535	15,455	-6.8%	-7.9%	-6.0%
Medicaid	6,665-6,815			6,958	7,170	6,780	7,490	-7.1%	-4.3%	-9.5%
International				1,063	1,049	1,145	1,165	-9.6%	-10.0%	-1.7%

Source: Company Reports, Deutsche Bank Research, Bloomberg Finance LP



Appendix 1

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Company	Ticker	Recent price	Disclosure
UnitedHealth Group	UNH.N	15.51 (USD) 16 Jul 26	7, 8, 14, 15, 21, 24, 26

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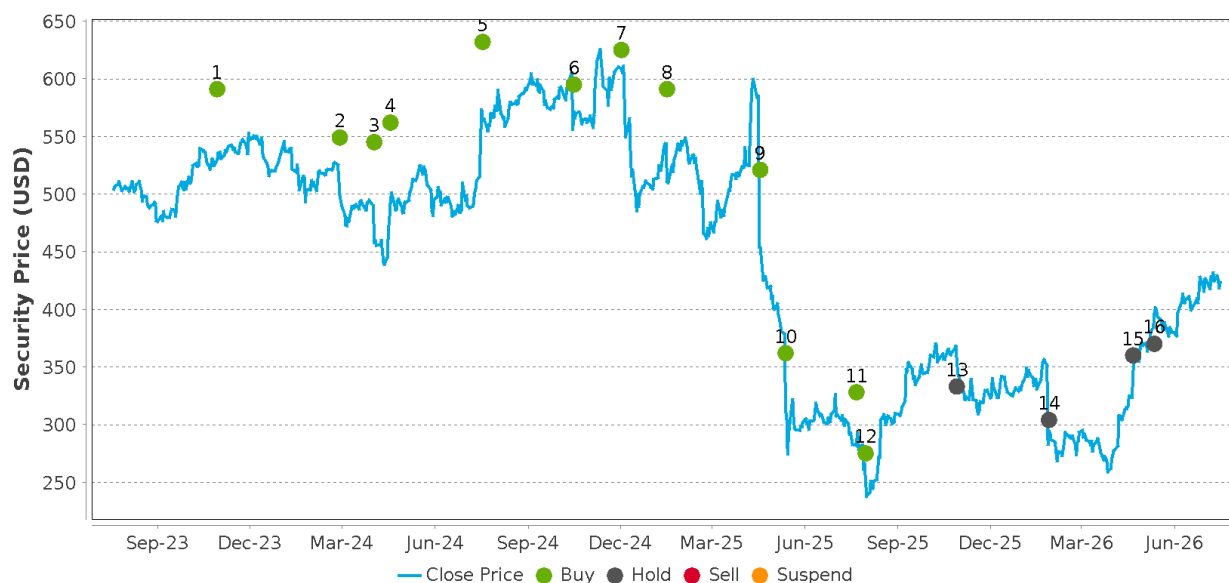
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Historical recommendations and target price: UnitedHealth Group (UNH.N)



1.	30 Oct 23	Price target: 591 (USD), close price 529.99 (USD), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: George Hill
2.	28 Feb 24	Price target: 549 (USD), close price 498.28 (USD), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: George Hill
3.	2 Apr 24	Price target: 545 (USD), close price 458.14 (USD), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: George Hill
4.	18 Apr 24	Price target: 562 (USD), close price 493.18 (USD), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: George Hill
5.	18 Jul 24	Price target: 632 (USD), close price 564.34 (USD), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: George Hill
6.	16 Oct 24	Price target: 595 (USD), close price 571.34 (USD), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: George Hill
7.	2 Dec 24	Price target: 625 (USD), close price 608.52 (USD), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: George Hill
8.	16 Jan 25	Price target: 591 (USD), close price 510.59 (USD), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: George Hill
9.	18 Apr 25	Price target: 521 (USD), close price 454.11 (USD), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: George Hill
10.	13 May 25	Price target: 362 (USD), close price 311.38 (USD), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: George Hill
11.	22 Jul 25	Price target: 328 (USD), close price 285.13 (USD), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: George Hill
12.	31 Jul 25	Price target: 275 (USD), close price 249.56 (USD), Recommendation: Buy, Analyst: George Hill
13.	29 Oct 25	Price target: 333 (USD), close price 355.26 (USD), Recommendation: Hold, Analyst: George Hill
14.	28 Jan 26	Price target: 304 (USD), close price 294.02 (USD), Recommendation: Hold, Analyst: George Hill
15.	21 Apr 26	Price target: 360 (USD), close price 346.01 (USD), Recommendation: Hold, Analyst: George Hill
16.	12 May 26	Price target: 370 (USD), close price 396.39 (USD), Recommendation: Hold, Analyst: George Hill





Company rating dispersion and banking relationships

DBSI Companies under Coverage	Buy	Hold	Sell
Covered	57%	42%	0%
w/ Banking relationship	42%	35%	0%
w/ MiFID services	63%	51%	67%

Global Companies under Coverage	Buy	Hold	Sell
Covered	58%	40%	2%
w/ Banking relationship	46%	32%	32%
w/ MiFID services	75%	69%	94%

Company Rating and Dispersion Key

The above table provides a snapshot of Deutsche Bank's company research rating distribution across our covered companies. We also present the percentage of companies where Deutsche Bank has provided Investment Banking Services in the past 12 months and/or MIFID Investment and Ancillary services, in the past 12 months. Please see the key and definition of our rating below.

Note - percentages are rounded so may not total 100%.

Covered: The overall rating distribution across all companies under coverage with a rating.

w/Banking relation: Percentage of companies under coverage with a rating within each of the "buy", "hold" and "sell" categories for which Deutsche Bank has provided Investment Banking Services within the previous 12 months.

w/MiFID services: Percentage of companies under coverage with a rating within each of the "buy", "hold" and "sell" categories for which Deutsche Bank has provided MIFID Investment and Ancillary services within the previous 12 months.

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Rating definitions:

Buy: Based on a current 12-month view of TSR, we recommend that investors buy the stock.

Sell: Based on a current 12-month view of TSR, we recommend that investors sell the stock.

Hold: We take a neutral view on the stock 12-months out and, based on this time horizon, do not recommend either a Buy or Sell.

TSR: Total Shareholder Return. Percentage change in share price from current price to projected target price plus projected dividend yield.

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